



The Picture We Stopped Looking At

The tracing boards

SYMBOLISM

Boards began as chalk drawn on the floor and mopped out at the close. What replaced the mop, what Josiah Bowring and John Harris put on the boards, and how much instruction is sitting in a picture that leans against the wall all evening.

ON THE TABLE

The lodge's own First Degree tracing board



Josiah Bowring (1757-1832) - First Degree Tracing Board - D2010-3 - Museum of Freemasonry — Josiah Bowring
Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:30	Part One: the mop and pail
4:00	Part Two: from floor to frame
6:30	Part Three: two men who painted them
10:00	Part Four: reading the First Degree board
15:00	Part Five: why a picture, and why it still works
17:30	Closing



THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Boards replaced designs drawn in chalk on the floor and mopped off at the close.
- 2 John Harris redesigned them; Emulation adopted his set in the 1840s and they became standard.
- 3 Harris went blind, and was kept until his death in 1873 by what is now the Masonic Charitable Foundation.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Why "tracing" board?

Operative term — the board on which the master traced the working drawings the craftsmen built from.

What came before boards?

The design drawn in chalk and charcoal on the floor, and washed off at the close, often by the youngest Entered Apprentice.

Who designed ours?

Almost certainly after John Harris (1791–1873), adopted by Emulation in the 1840s and standard in England since.

Bowring or Harris?

Bowring's designs came first, c.1819, and survive in older lodges. Harris's became the standard.

Are the boards jewels?

In the English working the tracing board is an immovable jewel, with the two ashlar.

What's a trestle board?

The same object in American usage — though the term now more often means a lodge's newsletter.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual — the explanations of the three tracing boards
- T. O. Haunch, Tracing Boards: Their Development and Their Designers (Ars Quatuor Coronatorum, vol. 75) — the standard study
- Harry Carr, The Freemason at Work
- Museum of Freemasonry, London — holds Harris and Bowring originals
- Your own board: look for a maker's mark, a date, and a donor's inscription on the reverse

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